Polluted Marrow

PandaHero

Info

Rating: Not Rated

Archive Warnings: Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category: F/F

Fandoms: Life is Strange (Video Game)

Relationships: Rachel Amber/Maxine "Max" Caulfield/Chloe Price, Rachel Amber/Chloe Price

Characters: Maxine "Max" Caulfield, Chloe Price (Life is Strange), Rachel Amber, Joyce Price, David Madsen, Mark Jefferson, Victoria Chase (Life is Strange), Kate Marsh, Warren Graham, Vanessa Caulfield

Additional Tags: Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Blood and Injury, Nosebleed, Nightmares, Implied/Referenced Rape/Non-con, Implied/Referenced Suicide, Time Travel, Rachel Amber Lives, Panic Attacks, Underage Drinking, Mark Jefferson Is His Own Warning, aka max gets her happy timeline but is way too fucked up to properly enjoy it ,:), no beta we die like rachel amber (except she's not dead in this one i promise , this is solidly an everybody lives au. just with a big side of Trauma, will be adding more tags as I go, Dissociation, Mild Gore, Non-Consensual Drug Use, Implied/Referenced Self-Harm

Language English

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Summary

Max has been looping through this wretched week over and over in search of a less fatal outcome, but after yet another particularly bad ending, she's driven to do a little more than just reset. Consequences be damned.

Notes

oh boy, this got out of hand. welcome to my very self-indulgent rachel-is-alive au, resurrected from a wip so old bts hadn't even come out yet when i started it. so i totally did not just end up in a coincidentally timed lis rabbit hole that left me so desperate for amberpricefield that i decided to start a dumb little multichap. totally. updates will probably be slow and sporadic, and i have no idea if i'm going to be cranking out chapters as long as this on the regular. i just really wanted a glimpse of everyone's thought process in this one, but i had a lot of fun doing all three povs so i might keep it up. who knows. title is taken from Spiracle by Flower Face (bc it's The messed up time-looper Max song.) chapter title is from Pools by Glass Animals CWs for this chapter: character death/suicide (impermanent), Max's category five

nosebleeds, talk of Jefferson and what happened in the Dark Room, panic attacks, underage drinking, talk of drugs (but no actual doing them)

shake my little soul for you

Chloe's jacket slips through her fingers. Max screams loud and long.

It's drowned out by the screeching winds, the pounding rain, but even when her throat gives out her ears can pick up the sickening crack of Chloe's body colliding with the rocks below. There's a single moment of petrification, where all Max can see is Chloe's limp, soaked form splayed across the cliff base. The way her right arm is twisted beyond repair. The smears of blood lining the rocks that her head had come into contact with on her descent. Then, the sea rises to swallow her whole, and Chloe is gone.

Chloe is *gone*.

Max glares down at the waves, and prays that Chloe washes up somewhere far, far away from here.

This isn't the first time she's watched Chloe die. Not by a long shot. With her constant rewinding and reliving this past week, Max has seen it 36 times, with incident marking the 37th. But it was different, this time.

It was all her fault.

It came purely, entirely, unquestionably from her own stubbornness. 36 dead Chloe Prices had proved too much for Max, and she'd been downright desperate to keep the girl alive this time around, to find a way to keep both her and the Bay safe and sound.

But Chloe always was the more bullheaded of the two of them. She refused to have Max sacrifice the entire town just for her sake. So Max had watched, frozen, as Chloe wrenched herself from her grip and tumbled into the sea below.

Max's next thought is the overwhelming urge to tip herself over the edge and follow suit. To put an end to this agonizing cycle. Let the storm tear through Arcadia Bay and not do a fucking thing about it.

But habit takes over, fogs up her brain like thick, acrid smoke and before she can even blink Max has her hand raised to rewind. She watches the world spin and whirl and mix and blur, sea spray and whipping winds, fragmented stone and chunks of debris. There's a sharp pang in the back of her head, and she can feel the blood dripping from her nose, but she doesn't stop. Ripping pressure erupts at the base of her neck, like a thousand of those little needles all stuffed into the one spot, but she doesn't stop. Her body aches and pounds and screams for her to stop, each individual nerve ripping apart at the seams, yet she does not lower her arm until it collapses under the weight of time compounded; leaving her panting, crying, bleeding on the ground.

With clipped breath and shaking arms, Max attempts to pull her phone from her jacket pocket. Her face nuzzles into the dirt beneath her, and she can see blood dampening the pebbles and patchy grass. Her limbs are papery, thin and weak and all too easy to shred, but she finally manages to bring the phone to her face. Getting her eyes to focus is another matter entirely, though the double vision fades in and out just enough for her to read a few numbers– always numbers, so many numbers, too many numbers in her head all the goddamn time.

10:17PM

A fit of coughs rattles through her ribcage. More. She needs more.

05/04/13

Her heart nearly stops.

Max makes her decision before she can even fully process what this all means. She forces herself to stand and tries her best to ignore the resulting roil of vertigo, as well as the steady dribble of blood from her nose and taste of iron lingering in her throat. Lurching forward, one weak leg in front of the other, each step sending sparks of pain rolling up her spine. She tries to pick up speed, she *tries* , but there's a limp in her left leg and she only makes it a few blocks past Two Whales before she falls to the ground. She catches herself on one arm, but her face still scrapes against the sidewalk and she can feel the gravel scratching at her cheeks, soon followed by an unbearable stinging as dirt and dust are forced into her eyes.

She wants to scream again. To wail at the top of her lungs, to cry out for someone, anyone to help her. But no one can help her. She has to do this on her own. She always does. She drags herself back into a standing position, continuing her hobble up to Blackwell, hoping in vain to blink her vision back to normal and spitting a foul mix of blood and bile into the gutter.

Few people are wandering campus when she makes it, and they all stare incredulously as she shuffles past them. A few even call out to ask what she's doing or if she needs a ride to the hospital. None of them recognize her, of course, but Max doesn't care. All Max cares about is getting to Rachel before she can take a single goddamn step out of her dorm room.

She trips twice on the stairs, and she knows that she's trailing blood all over the fresh tile flooring, but Max continues her climb

regardless. She remembers the room number — Chloe had told her once, she doesn't know when or where — though she winds up not needing it. She can see the girl's name written in bold, red cursive on the whiteboard outside her door.

And she uses the last of her remaining energy to thunk herself against that door, too drained to even lift her hand to knock. Rachel's voice floats through, and though it's the first time Max has heard it she knows then that Chloe was right, that this girl is an angel.

"Hello?" she asks, and Max can hear her crossing the room in a huff. "Victoria, that better not be your drunk ass trying to get into the wrong room again."

Rachel swings the door open with exceptional vigor and sends max tumbling to the floor in the process.

"Shit, fuck, what the hell–"

Max looks up at her through strained eyes, Rachel Amber and her ghostly afterimage dancing around each other in slow, sickly circles. The weight of the situation sinks in. Rachel is here. Rachel is *alive*. Max can save her, and save Chloe, and Kate, and put a stop to Jefferson and Nathan. She just has to keep track of every little moment, every little detail, every molecule of minutia going on around her. But she's tired. She's so, so tired. Already yesterday melds with tomorrow, fuses ten minutes from now to last Wednesday, mixes junkyard scrap with sunny snow.

"Can you hear me? C'mon, c'mon, talk to me."

All the different incidents, outcomes and conversations swarm in Max's mind and she's hopeless; she's desperate and dying on the Blackwell dorm floors and all she can get out are pleas so that's what she does.

"J-Jefferson," Max wheezes, coughs blood onto the floor beside her. "Dangerous. Don't go. Please, please don't go."

A moment of tense silence follows. "The only place we're going is the ER," Rachel answers, distant and grim.

Panic seizes Max's heart in a quick, crushing grip, and her body convulses in kind. "No hospital," she begs, whimpering at the phantom smell of disinfectant, the muddled memory of a syringe pinching at her neck. She doesn't know how many times it happened. "No hospital. No Jefferson."

She can still feel his hands on her. The heat of the lights, the duct tape around her wrists. The cold floor against her face as Jefferson's voice swung effortlessly between hazed praise and hellish anger. She can still see that photo of Rachel, huddled in the corner, bound but furious. The photos of Kate. The photos of herself.

"Okay, okay, no hospital. Just– Just try to breathe, alright?"

Max feels herself being pulled into a sitting position, leaned up against a body far studier than her own, warm cloth pressed against her face. She shudders through an inhale.

"That's it, there you go." Rachel's voice treads the line between manic concern and stone cold calm, but Max can't get enough of it. Every word out of her mouth translates straight into guilt-laden elation.

I can save her. Her mind rejoices, howls out in sweet, sombre victory. *I did it. I can save her. I can save them both.*

"Hey, hey."

The ceiling rumbles with thunder. The walls flash white and bright.

"Stay with me, c'mon, stay with me."

Max's eyes roll back. Her mouth twitches up into a smile.

The world fades in and out for a little while, a tangled web of sights and sounds she left behind spinning and blooming into being. Despite how often it's happened at this point, Max will never get used to it. One minute she's back in that storm, deafening winds and crackling lightning there to greet her with open arms. The next, she's in The Dark Room, tied to that chair and staring down at the empty space where Victoria had been. Another blink, and she's back in the dorms with Rachel's signature red and black flannel held to her nose.

Rachel is on the phone with someone, all traces of her earlier composure having vanished. She still has an arm around Max, holding her steady as she speaks. "There's blood- Like, *a lot* of blood. And she won't stop shaking."

Only because of the wind, Max wants to say. But her throat is too tight, and Rachel's voice is so hard to hear over the storm. Or maybe that's just the blood rushing in her ears.

"She– She just showed up at my door and totally collapsed on me."

Rachel looks pretty in the rain.

"She said no hospital. Fuck, man, I don't know. Just get here as quick as you can."

Max won't let anything happen to her. Not this time.

Think, Max, *think*, she tells herself, gazing up at the cut of Rachel's jawline, the calm blue of her feather earring. *You need to stop him. You need to save them* . She shifts a little, forces her heavy eyelids to stay open, willing her body to get back up and run to David's office. She hardly moves an inch.

"Take it easy. Are you back with me?"

Max shrugs as best she can. It doesn't matter to her if she's all there or not, all that matters is that she gets up.

"Need to… keep going." It takes a considerable amount of effort to form the words, like she's wading waist deep in a pool of cold molasses just to search for them. She struggles in vain to free herself from Rachel's grip.

"Uhm, no the fuck you don't," huffs Rachel, utterly flabbergasted and keeping Max still with barely any effort at all. "What you need to do is rest. And you certainly aren't gonna get any here in the palace of shitty mattresses and nosy neighbors, so I'm taking you to a friend's place."

She must mistake the desperation in Max's expression for fear, because she immediately continues, tone hushed and even.

"No hospital, just a friend. I promise. They've got a first aid kit, and the bed over there is *way* comfier than mine. Trust me, you'll thank me later."

But she can't rest now, no matter how much she may want to. Not when she's so close. Not when she can save them both. Not when she knows there's an empty binder with Rachel's name on it. "Gotta… help…"

"*You* need help." Max swears those hazel eyes are glowing, haloed, bright enough to scare away any shadow. "You look like you've been stuck out in the rain too, you poor thing."

Max could cry. She probably is, now that she thinks about it. She's never been so happy to be held in a dead girl's arms.

"Storm," the word tumbles from her lips with no resistance. "Always so c-c-cold."

Rachel makes this sort of horrified, sort of sad expression. Whatever she's feeling, her voice remains measured and steady. "I'll grab you something warm, and then we can see about getting you up. Sound good?"

Slowly, carefully, Rachel loosens her grip, allowing Max to sit on her own. Or try to, anyways, the waves of dizziness have yet to fully subside and Max has a pit in her stomach like her body thinks it might teeter into the ocean at any second, but it's nothing she hasn't dealt with before. She watches through her still swirling vision as Rachel rifles through her closet with all the speed and ferocity of a cracked out cheetah, pulling out the first sweater she can find and rushing back over to Max's side. It's a hoodie, and though the fabric's wear and tear is telling of its age it's no detriment to its comfort. The inside is lined with a soft fleece, and as Rachel zips it up Max can't help but let out a sigh of relief. It feels like it's been years since the last time she was warm.

Rachel keeps talking to her as they make their way down to the parking lot, gentle nothings and repetitive reassurances that are probably more for herself than for Max. She wards Victoria away with some sort of snappy remark, assures Kate that everything will be fine, gives Juliet a rushed explanation laced with white lies. Max isn't paying much attention to her little chameleon display, too preoccupied with plotting out her desired order of events.

First, she'll tell David, make sure he stops Jefferson before he can lay a hand on Rachel, Kate, or Victoria. Then, once she's found the courage to look the girl in the eyes after driving her to a suicide she can never remember, she'll apologize to Chloe, presumably introduce herself to Rachel in a less ominous context, and find some way to keep them both the hell away from Nathan. Simple. Easy.

“Yo, Rach. Over here.”

Max freezes. She should have guessed. Who else would Rachel have been on the phone with.

“Chloe, thank fuck, let's–”

"Max?!"

Shit. Shit shit shit. It wasn't supposed to go this way, she didn't want Chloe to see her like this. Not again. She promised that she wouldn't. She needs more time, there's never enough time.

But it's alright. She'll just rewind and–

Pain surges between her eyes, searing hot and jagged as the rocks beneath the lighthouse. She turned back all of three seconds. Too little to do anything meaningful, just enough to cause trouble.

"Chloe, thank fuck, let's– What the hell? When did she–"

Rachel is no longer at her side, now lagging a few steps behind. Max can hear her talking, but all she sees is Chloe.

Chloe, with her raggedy jacket and her striking blue hair. Chloe, with her gruff, familiar voice and oh so snarky attitude. Chloe, who Max loves more than anything. Chloe, who ripped herself from Max's arms and threw herself into the bay.

Chloe, alive, breathing, and looking right at her.

"Max?!"

Despite it all, relief hits her like a freight train. She gives a weak laugh at the comparison — though it's more akin to a pitiful wheeze — and all of the adrenaline drains from her body in one fell swoop, leaving her battered and limp and so, so *happy*. She hits the asphalt with an echoing crunch.

"Oh God, oh God *Max*."

"Shit, shit, she's bleeding again, fuck."

It's almost funny, having Chloe and Rachel knelt at her side, staring down at her body for once. The world goes dark.

A groan tumbles from her numb lips. She tries to lift her heavy head.

"Max! You fucked up my shot!"

That voice, like ice prickling along her spine. She can't get her body to move, to get up, to *run* .

Not even when the storm rolls over the beachside, the lighthouse breaking away into big chunks of concrete all hurtling in her direction.

Not even when she's got her face mashed up against junkyard trash, watching the bullet rip through Chloe's chest, Rachel dead and buried beneath them.

She can hear him pushing the cart closer, the metallic grind and scrape of the wheels rolling across the floor, how the one in the top left corner squeaks at a slightly higher pitch than all the others.

"Oh, Max."

He steps towards her in three slow strides. She knows what he's going to do. She *knows* , but can't do anything to stop it. She can never stop him. She'll always end up here, under his leering eyes, under his horrid touch.

"You're almost more trouble than you're worth."

A hand on her back. A pinch in her neck.

"Almost."

Max bolts upright with enough force to send herself crashing to the floor in a tangle of blankets and sheets. Her limbs offer their complaint by throbbing in pain, but Max is more focused on gasping for breath, backing as far away as possible. She has to think of a way out while she's still sober and conscious, she has to, but her mind stutters and fumbles and flickers in and out of that helpless, drug induced daze and he's going to get her again, he's going to touch her again, he's–

"Whoa, easy there, Super Max."

If his voice is cutting ice, then Chloe's is bright, blaring sunlight. Warm and familiar, scorching and sharp. It cuts in a different way.

She pries her eyes open, and the first thing she notices is just how *blue* Chloe's hair is. The dye must have faded by the time October came around. Comes around. Whichever.

"I'm sorry." The words are heavy on her tongue, despite how many times she's thought about them, how many times she's said them. Her throat is raspy and raw, and forcing her brain and vocal chords to work in tandem is as laborious as holding a rewind for too long. "S-sorry, Chloe. Wasn't– wasn't there for you."

"Are you seriously launching into your grand apology speech right now?" Chloe gapes back at her, eyes wide and wild and rimmed with a dark purple hue. "Fuck that. Max, what the hell happened to you?"

Ah, that's right. She's doing things out of order already. Classic Max, fucking things up at every opportunity. "Sorry," she says again, like it's the only word her body will allow her to say. "I'm sorry."

"You need to breathe. Both of you."

This voice is still new. Uncanny and alien and fascinating enough to coax Max into listening.

"Right," Chloe grits, closing her eyes and letting out a harsh sigh. "Thanks, Rach."

Max trembles through an inhale, feels every inch of her body groan in protest to her being alive. A few more half steady breaths allot her enough clarity in both mind and vision to see that she's in Chloe's room, sunlight streaming in through the flag draped over the window and painting the floors in red and white glow. The

posters on the wall, the boxes and clutter, the faint smell of weed that's always clinging to the air, all of it a stark reminder of the lack of danger. And of course, Chloe herself, knelt down in front of Max with frantic concern written all over her features.

Her body moves of its own accord, and she practically launches herself into Chloe, wrapping her arms around her and holding her close. Holding tight, like she should have at the lighthouse.

"Missed you," she mumbles into the fabric of Chloe's tank top, voice creaking with the effort it takes to push the words up her aching throat. "Missed you so much."

"I… I missed you too, Max."

Chloe returns the embrace, cautious and hesitant, and for a few blessed moments she actually feels *safe*. No swirling storm, no snapping shutters. Just Max and her partner in crime.

"Here."

And Rachel. That's going to take some getting used to.

Chloe shifts to the side and instinct slaps Max upside the head in a cold rush, leading her to grip the back of the girl's shirt in white-knuckled anticipation. She needs to keep her here. She needs to keep her out of danger.

"It's okay. I'm not goin' anywhere." Chloe's voice has dropped to a murmur, smooth and steady. The kind of tone she used to use to coax Max out from under the covers during horror movie marathons. "Max, c'mon. I need you to let me go so we can get up."

Max doesn't want to let go.

Still, she loosens her grip, lets her arms fall slack and stares holes into the floor as Chloe helps her back into bed. She's handed a bottle of water as Chloe gives her as proper an introduction to Rachel as she can, which she proceeds to absolutely devour in

hopes the hydration will make talking a little easier. All the while, they watch her like a pair of nervous hawks. Blue eyes fixated on the sharp jut of her jawbone, hazel eyes searching her expression for clues.

Max manages a small, “Thanks,” as she finishes, and Rachel takes the empty bottle with a wavering sense of calm. She’s clearly shaken up — who wouldn’t be after seeing something like that — but she keeps it all under lock and smiling key.

Chloe, on the other hand, looks as if it's taking every fibre of her being to keep her cool. Her brows are furrowed, and her left leg is jittering about like it's late for a meeting. “Max,” she breathes, “What happened to you?”

It's the second time she's asked, and judging by the dangerous glint in her eye she isn't ready to hear the whole truth. Max will have to be careful with her words. Which is kind of a problem considering she only seems capable of stammering broken bits and pieces of her internal monologue.

Case in point: the very much private thought of *I got myself kidnapped by a perverted egomaniac*, turns into a quivering utterance of, “Pervert.”

Which is definitely *not* what Chloe wanted to hear, if the burst of anger in her expression is anything to go by. Max heaves a sigh and rewinds before Chloe can even open her mouth. This time around the sudden failing of her powers feels less like a shot to the forehead and more like the usual fizzling migraine, which is a definite improvement. It seems she's still limited to a few seconds at a time, but that's enough for now.

Then it happens again. From *I got caught in a storm*, to just, “Caught.”

A second rewind leaves her seeing double, and this time Max chooses to stay quiet.

“Did… Did someone hurt you?”

She flicks her gaze over to Rachel. It's strange to see color in her face, to see her blinking and breathing and not lifelessly plastered all over the town in monochrome, but Max likes it. That, and she doesn't want to risk overtaxing herself any more than she already has. She nods, small and stiff.

Chloe pales as she repeatedly curls and unfurls her fists. The question comes like concrete crushing through her grit teeth. “Who. Who hurt you, Max?”

Max just shakes her head. She can't be honest — *I hurt me. I brought this on myself. I deserve this* — and she can't have Chloe flying off the handle and running to try and deal with Jefferson herself. She can't have Chloe running off *period* . Her heart can't take it.

Rachel puts a hand on Chloe's shoulder, gives it a light squeeze. “Why don't you go tell your mom that Max is up,” she offers with another one of those tempered half-smiles. Her tone suggests it's not an option.

Chloe looks between them both, dilemma clear as day on her face, but eventually she sighs again and moves to stand. “Yeah, alright,” she huffs, floorboards creaking as she crosses the room. “I won't be long,” she adds, most definitely for Max's sake.

Rachel watches her leave, listens to her thunking down the stairs, and once she seems to think Chloe is far enough she turns back to Max with curious fire in her eyes. She doesn't speak, not at first. She looks Max up and down, tilts her head and leans in for a closer look at her face, and Max starts to feel like an ant under the magnifying glass of her piercing gaze.

"Jefferson."

Even just hearing his name makes Max nauseous.

"I don't know how much of last night you remember, but you told me he was dangerous. Did he…?"

Though left unasked, Rachel's question sits cold and heavy in Max's stomach. A whimper crawls its way out of her throat, and she prays her pleading expression will say everything for her.

"I won't tell Chloe, if that's what you're worried about. Promise."

Rachel matches her desperate look with one of genuine worry, and Max is suddenly very aware of the girl's famed reputation as someone you can never say no to. And she did keep her promise to not take Max to the hospital. Besides, Rachel has a right to know; in some morose, mangled way.

Everyone will find out sooner or later. It'll make national headlines.

The real issue is that she can't answer one way or the other in full confidence. He had said he didn't do anything, that all he wanted was to have his fun posing her, but Max isn't exactly trustful of his word. She'll never wash away the algid burn of his touch, the memory of him growling, "*God, those eyes.*" When she finally opens her mouth, her voice sounds dull and distant.

"Pictures." The thought pools thick and bitter on her tongue. She keeps her gaze fixed on the blankets. Then, she gestures to her neck. "Needle."

All of that color drains from Rachel's face in an instant.

The sound of hurried footsteps on the stairs draws both of them to flinch in the direction of the door, only to see one Joyce Price rushing in at the speed of light. She's by Max's side before

she can even blink, holding her face in both hands, reaching up to smooth her hair back.

“Oh, Maxine, sweetheart you gave us such a scare last night.” Her voice washes over Max like the first sip of hot cocoa on a cold day. Joyce is the only one who's allowed to call her that. “How are you feeling?”

After thinking on it for a moment, Max decides on, “Head hurts.” Because it does, it feels like the universe reached right into her skull and made scrambled eggs of her brain. Not that the rest of her feels any better, every molecule of every muscle aches like she tore herself in pieces and now her body is trying to sew itself back together. Which she probably did, in a weird, complicated metaphysical sense, but it was worth it to see Chloe and Rachel alive again.

“I'd say. You had such an awful nosebleed when you came in.” She looks Max over, studies her face, her own expression twisting more and more into one of melancholy with each passing second. “You look so much older than when I last saw you.”

Something inside of Max snaps at that. The final straw, so to speak. She feels decades older than she should be, and God only knows how accurate a statement that is. She’s rewound and photo-jumped and reset too many times to count, peeling back the layers and forcing herself deeper and deeper into the rabbit hole. Even now, there's that same uncanny disconnect of being eighteen in her thirteen year old self's body. Like she’s intruding. Like she’s taking someone else’s happiness. Like she doesn't belong here.

She only vaguely registers the sound of Rachel excusing herself to go join Chloe downstairs. She's too busy trying not to cry.

“What happened, baby? Do Ryan and Vanessa know where you're at?”

Maybe Max should feel worse than she does about the fact that she hasn't even thought of them yet. From their perspective she'll have vanished from her bedroom overnight and somehow made it back to Arcadia Bay all on her own, albeit bloodied and clearly worse for wear. What she does feel, at the mention of her parents, at the thought of being back in Seattle, is near primal fear.

"Don't wanna go," she begs, all rational thought lost to the prospect of being taken away from Chloe. Again. "N-Need to stay here. Please don't make me go."

She'd pat herself on the back for finally managing a full sentence if only it didn't drain her of so much energy. Her lower lip trembles, and her eyes go blurry as the tears spill over. Joyce sits beside her and gathers her up in a hug, running a hand up and down her back, telling her it's alright, everything is alright now. It feels more real when someone else is saying it.

"It's okay, sweetheart. No one's making you leave," Joyce assures, reaching up to stroke Max's hair. "You're in no shape to be going anywhere as it is."

But Max just cries and cries, powerless to stop the flood of guilt and panic and ice cold horror that's been festering inside of her for weeks and weeks on end. She clings to Joyce like a lifeline, basks in the protective warmth of familial bonds she's been trying so hard to keep intact. Even as her mind wails of how undeserving, how unworthy she is after all the times she's let Chloe die, all the times David got hurt trying to save her.

Shit, David. She has to tell David. She opens her mouth to try and say as much. No sound comes out. Her head throbs in complaint. As Joyce pulls back, Max spots a drop of blood on her shirt, and hurries to cover her nose.

“Oh, honey,” Joyce croons, brows upturned in sympathy. She grabs one of several tissue boxes that Max had failed to notice crowding the bedside table, pulling a few out and handing them to her. Luckily it seems to be minor, though Joyce still walks her through the process of leaning forward and pinching her nose for a few minutes. “The girls said that you didn't want to go to the hospital,” she says, rubbing slow circles on Max's back. “But are you sure? I'm worried about you, Maxine. This seems pretty serious.”

Max nods as hard as she can. “M'sure,” she whispers, wincing as she feels the tissues soaking further. She reaches out a shaking hand to grab a couple more.

Joyce gives her a long, mournful look before sighing in much the same way Chloe had earlier. “Alright, dear. If you say so. You let me know right away if you change your mind.” Her smile doesn't reach her eyes. “Could I talk you into some pancakes, at least? I bet you're hungry.”

The ghost of a nostalgic grin plays across Max's face. She nods again. She'd never say no to Joyce's pancakes.

“You just get some rest, then. I'll bring some up for you when they're ready.”

Max wishes people would stop telling her that, but recognizes that she doesn't have much choice. She needs to get back in fighting shape as soon as possible if she's going to keep Chloe and Rachel safe.

Rachel bites back a wave of nausea as she turns the corner into the Price's kitchen.

Pictures. Needle. Her skin crawls.

It paints a vague portrait, sure, but it’s almost worse to have so much left up to her imagination. She struggles to wrap her

head around it, to make sense of the idea that one of her favorite teachers is actually some five-star predator, but she certainly has no reason to believe Max is lying either.

Mark Jefferson has taken a liking to her, as of late. Consistently complimenting her work, calling on her more often in class. Little remarks here and there, telling her what shame it is that she's always behind the camera. Charming smiles and secretive winks. Jokingly inviting her to his studio under the promise of helping build her modelling portfolio. Rachel hadn't thought anything of it. In fact, she'd been more than happy to bask in his positive attention, figuring she would do well to keep him at her beck and call and squeeze a few favors out of him.

Pictures. Needle. It's amazing how only two words can turn your perception of the world on its head.

She has photography class this afternoon.

Rachel pushes the thought from her mind, instead turning her attention to Chloe, who's pacing back and forth in front of the counter, bottom lip ground between her teeth. Beyond strange, it's off-putting to see her so genuinely rattled. It always makes her heart ache to see her big tough badass looking so small and scared.

“Are you… okay?”

“Okay?” Chloe scoffs. “No, I'm not fucking okay. Somebody in this godforsaken shithole fucking *hurt* my friend and–”

She whips around to meet Rachel's eyes, but deflates upon seeing her.

“And I shouldn't be taking it out on you. Sorry.” She runs a hand through her hair before letting her arms drop to her sides.

“Backing off a fight before it even starts?” Rachel muses, plastering on her most comforting smile and reaching out to take the girl's hands in her own. “You really must be out of sorts.”

Chloe gives a weak huff of laughter at that, rolling her eyes and squeezing Rachel's hands. “It's just– I thought when she finally showed up after all this time I'd… y'know.”

“Tear her a new one?” supplies Rachel with a quirk of her brow.

She's heard plenty of Chloe's fantasy reunions with the infamous Max Caulfield, most of which involved chewing her out and having her buy Chloe lunch, quote, 'for the rest of forever.' Rachel always held her doubts that Chloe could keep the grudge alive once they were face to face, but she never imagined it would turn out like this.

“Yeah. And then maybe we’d catch up, spend the day together like nothing even happened. But she's– She's so fucked up, Rach. All of this is so fucked up.”

Rachel listens to the harshness of Chloe's breathing, notes the way she can barely keep still, the furious glint in her eye that only ever shows up when she's thinking of doing something foolish. They may have spent five years in radio silence, but Max still seems to know Chloe well enough to know when to hold her tongue. Rachel can almost picture the way she would peel out of the driveway in that beaten up old truck of hers, speeding her way down to Blackwell and confronting Jefferson herself.

If she hadn't heard what she did, Rachel might have let her.

“Girls?”

For the second time this morning, Rachel jumps at the sound of Joyce approaching. God, she really needs to get it together.

“Yeah?” Chloe answers, perking up much the same way as a search dog who's just caught a scent. Rachel's never seen her so morbidly focused.

When Joyce enters the kitchen, she wears an expression of grief and worry. “Chloe, you'll be staying home to keep an eye on her, right?”

“Of course I am,” Chloe nods, and her lack of comment on the free day off school only adds to the air of wrongness permeating this whole situation.

“Good, good.” Joyce shuffles her way around the cupboards, and Rachel recognizes the growing slew of items as preparation for pancakes. “Why don't you go and keep her company while I get some breakfast settled.”

Chloe's halfway up the stairs before Joyce can even finish the sentence.

“Oh, and Rachel?”

“Hm?”

Joyce pulls her into a hug. “Thank you,” she murmurs, “For taking care of Maxine. You're a real guardian angel, you know that?”

Hardly, Rachel wants to say. *I didn't guard her from anything, I just found her.*

Instead, she hums in agreement. “No worries. I'm just glad she's okay.”

“Me too,” Joyce agrees with a sigh. “Now, go on up and join 'em. David and I can drop you off at the school once we've all gotten some food into us.”

Rachel nods, thanks her, swallowing the urge to roll her eyes at the thought of being stuck in the car with step-douche. He at least had the decency to freak the fuck out along with the rest of them when Chloe and Rachel had dragged an unconscious, blood-soaked Max through the front door. Hell, this is the first time

he's given Rachel express permission to stay the night, let alone straight up ask her to.

Truth be told, she doesn't have a goddamn clue what to do with herself right now.

She imagined her first meeting with Max to be a little awkward, sure. Tense, maybe– and that's a hard maybe. From what she's been told, Max has the disposition of a startled rabbit; quiet and jumpy, but she'll warm up to almost anyone with time. Rachel always figured Chloe would have to act as middleman in introducing them. Having Max show up at her dorm with her brain exploding out of her nose? Definitely not on the metaphorical bingo card.

She hadn't even thought to ask her name.

Max could have died there on Rachel's floor, and she'd never have known whose corpse she was holding. When she closes her eyes, she can still see the image of stark red rivulets dribbling down that pale, lifeless face. Haunted, cloudy eyes boring into her own as Max croaked out raspy warnings and desperate pleads.

She looks a little better this morning. A little.

Rachel watches from the doorway as Chloe frets over her. She's still pale, and her face has the sunken, sallow look of someone who's been skipping one too many meals, someone who’s shivered half their body mass away. She doesn't seem up to talking much, though even when she had been earlier she didn't seem capable of more than a few disjointed words at a time. Still, Rachel can see light in her eyes; gears turning, thoughts flying by at a thousand miles a minute.

One thing is clear.

Max Caulfield is no rabbit. She bears the wild, watchful gaze of a hare.

She does, however, absolutely brighten at the sight of Joyce's pancakes. Chloe does too, grinning ear to ear and wasting no time shovelling a forkful into her mouth.

"Letting me eat in my room?" She asks, words muffled by syrupy fluff. "The world must be ending!"

"Don't get used to it, Chloe," Joyce chides. "I just didn't want Max to have to go down all those stairs."

Rachel hardly touches her plate. Max gives her a weighty, indecipherable look. Chloe makes a joke about there being more for her, but she follows it up with that stupid, endearing little pout that means she'll be asking about it later. Luckily, Rachel's got a temporary escape in the form of school. As shitty an escape as Blackwell is, it's better than nothing.

Joyce calls out to her from downstairs, prompting Max to give Chloe a quizzical look.

"Rachel's gotta get to class," she explains. "Something about taking notes, wanting decent grades, blah blah, I don't get it."

"You wouldn't." Rachel laughs, a hollow, duplicitous thing.

Max just keeps staring at her. Sharp, calculating, as if she can see right through each and every layer of Rachel's meticulously arranged smoke and mirrors in only a glance. Then, those bushy little brows of hers knit themselves together in unfettered concern, and her voice is barely above a whisper when she says, "Careful."

Rachel shudders. Chloe frowns.

The first thing Rachel does — after speed walking away from David Madsen and back to the dorms as fast humanly possible, of course — is hit up Frank. She'd promised herself she wouldn't do this anymore, but a bigger part of her kind of feels like she deserves a treat after everything she's witnessed in the past twelve hours. She keeps it light, at least. Just some booze.

But a thought strikes her, as she makes her way into the stairwell and spots the faint stains of hastily cleaned pools of blood dotting all the way up into the halls. A few more mark the shambled path to her door. Past Juliet's room. Past Victoria's room. Past Kate's room.

Why did Max come to her?

Someone must have seen her entering campus. She had to have passed by some students on her way up. There were plenty, *plenty* of places and people to stop and ask for help in a far more immediate vicinity than Rachel.

So why did drag herself all the way up here?

She couldn't have known whose door she'd stopped at. The warning about Jefferson was just the panicked babbling of a recently traumatized girl and not specific to Rachel. It's all just some hella freaky coincidence.

Right?

"There you are, Amber."

Victoria has a very recognizable and uniquely aggravating way of gritting out her name.

"What the fuck was up with that girl last night?" The blonde snarls, lingering in her doorway. "And couldn't you have gotten her out any faster? It still smells like goddamn blood out here."

Rachel narrows her eyes. "Not sure. I wasn't family, so the hospital didn't tell me." It's not entirely a lie. "And she's fine, by the way. Thanks so much for your concern."

"Really? Th-That's good."

Both of them turn to the source of the interruption. Kate Marsh, leaned halfway out of her own door, hunched in on herself and blinking up at the two of them like she's staring down a couple of hungry wolves.

Now Kate, Kate is a rabbit.

Small and soft and meek. You could corner her so easily. She'd hardly make a sound, too afraid of being an inconvenience to speak up. She wouldn't stand a chance.

Something twists in Rachel's stomach, acidic and grim.

“Hey, Amber, we're still talking to you.” She looks over at Victoria. “What the fuck is your problem today?”

For all her tough talk and attempts to act like the baddest bitch in town, Victoria wouldn't fare any better. Jefferson is bigger than her in both senses of the word. He would overpower her easily.

“Lay off, Chase,” she spits, mostly on autopilot. “I'm fine. I just didn't get much sleep with everything going on.”

That isn't much of a lie either. She really is off her game today.

“What the fuck ever,” Victoria huffs, “It's not like I care anyways.” With that, she slips back into her room, slamming her door.

Kate shrinks away at the sound, and Rachel wonders how many others at Blackwell have come to see her as an easy target.

“It's too early to deal with her yapping,” she whispers with an exaggerated roll of her eyes, half an attempt at placating the girl and half earnest thought. Kate gives her a nervous smile in return, and they too part ways.

So, school doesn't turn out to be the distraction Rachel was hoping for. Aside from her own concerns, talk of 'the nosebleed chick' is already flying in every direction. Most of the speculation tends towards painting her as a wayward junkie. Some say she was a drug-addled freak on the hunt for cash for her next fix, others think she was a partier who'd had one too many lines and got lost. Regardless of the imagined details, everyone seems to agree that she was just some ne'er-do-well strung out on a bad dose of something and wandering somewhere she didn't belong.

Fortunately, Chloe isn't here to hear any of it. Unfortunately, several people have the gall to approach Rachel and ask about it.

"What'd you do with the druggie?"

"I heard she snuck in. Did she try to take anything from you?"

"I don't know how you managed, I wouldn't have touched her. Who knows where she's been."

Least expected yet decidedly high on the list of worst-case scenarios, a certain bespectacled teacher stops her in the hallway for a quick chat about the matter. The lunch bell just rang, and he had apparently forced his way back through the flow of students to catch up with her.

He looks no different, but Rachel doesn't see the same man she did yesterday.

"There's my star student," he greets with his usual charming smirk. It's the same thing he always says, same wording, same intonation. It feels like someone poured ice down her back.

"Hey, Mr. Jefferson," she returns with a smile, hoping it's more believable than it feels. "To what do I owe the pleasure?"

His eyes dart from side to side. His voice lowers as if indulging her in the utmost of secrets. "I just wanted to tell you that I'm proud of you. For helping that girl."

Unease prickles across her skin. Is he… testing her? Getting scope of her knowledge on his victim to see if she poses any threat? He smiles again. His teeth look sharp.

She parries with a grin of her own, bright and blinding and so, so fake. "Word sure travels fast in Blackwell."

"Not much good, I'm afraid." He lays a hand on her shoulder, squeezes just so. "But you did the right thing, Rachel. I'm just glad you were there for her when you were."

Max's broken, empty voice rings in the back of her head.

Dangerous.

"Same here."

No hospital. No Jefferson.

His fingertips ghost against her arm as he pulls away. "Oh, while I still have you, could we have a word after class? There's something I've been meaning to speak with you about."

Pictures. Needle.

"But I think I've bent your ear enough for now. Run along and enjoy the rest of your lunch hour."

She layers her voice in candy-coated ignorance, bats her eyes like the perfect, bashful doe he wants her to be. "Sure, no problem."

She counts the seconds until he finally turns away. One, two, three. They each disappear into the crowd.

Rachel has never ditched campus so fast in her life. She'll probably get in major shit with Wells again, and she'll definitely be on the receiving end of another more-than-stern talking to from her father, but none of that matters right now. What matters is getting that drink.

Because what the fuck. What the actual, sideways, everloving *fuck*.

Rachel is no stranger to feeling threatened, to putting herself in dangerous situations and having to fly by the seat of her pants. She's putting herself in one right now by meeting up with Frank. At this point, she likes to think she has a pretty good radar for danger. She knows how to weave her way around an argument, how to armor herself in the safety of masks, how to cut and run when shit gets ugly.

Which is what makes it so idiotic, so frustrating, so goddamn *terrifying* that she never thought twice about Mark Jefferson. She thought he was harmless. Just a well-meaning man with, if any-

thing, an overt willingness to indulge her. But she should know that indulgence is always a slippery slope.

How many times has he held her after class to talk?

How many times has his hand lingered against her for just a moment too long?

Does he see her as a meal? As sweet, innocent prey?

She lets the whiskey burn the questions from her mind, for now. The cinnamon fire tastes like home.

Rachel Amber is no shaking rabbit, no fumbling doe. Rachel Amber is a dragon. Rachel Amber has claws and fangs.

She'll fucking kill that freak herself if he ever touches her again. And if he thinks he can use her to get to Max, he's got another thing coming.

Chloe has the weirdest dream. And that's saying a lot because trippy, bizzarro nightmares have long since become part of her day to day routine.

It's about Max. Which isn't all that surprising, given the circumstances. She's running from something, *fast*, scruffy brown hair whipping around in the violent winds and rain cascading down onto her. The scenery shifts several times; from the path leading up the lighthouse, to the junkyard, to the road outside Two Whales. Places Chloe knows, places she swears she’s never seen. Max is always running. She looks so lost, so scared, but Chloe can't do anything to reach for her.

So she watches, paralyzed, as Max runs and runs and runs, growing only more desperate with every step, more panicked.

“Wow, look at it go!”

“Dad?”

She can't see him, but she'd know that voice anywhere. It's accompanied by the shuffle of crow's wings. "Chloe, look! Do you see that hare?"

"Dad, that's– That's Max."

She can hear the soft smile in his voice, when he says, "No, it's a hare." Almost like she was young again, and he was correcting a childhood misconception in his old jovial, gentle way. "You can tell by the size. Rabbits are much smaller and rounder, while a hare is bigger and more wiry."

Chloe swallows. "… Right."

"Hares are solitary creatures," he continues, voice drifting to the left and lilting back to the right with no rhyme or reason. "They do everything all on their own, with no one to help them. Can you imagine what it's like to live like that?"

That doesn't sound like Max. At least, not the Max she knew.

Thunder rumbles above them.

"That's why they run," her father says, voice distorting as it always does, melding with the sound of oncoming traffic. "It's all they can do to survive."

When she finally startles herself awake, the dream is already dissolving from her grasp, but Chloe still acts on the immediate urge to hold Max tighter in her arms, breathing quick and thin.

Sunlight peaks through her makeshift curtains. The faint electric buzz and staticy, muffled dialogue of the cartoons playing in the background are next to draw her attention. Max is out like a light, curled up at her side with one of her small, boney hands keeping loose grip on Chloe's shirt. They must have fallen asleep after putting something on the TV.

Their morning hadn't been very eventful, thank merciful fuck. After getting some food into her, Chloe had spent another little

while trying to worm some answers out of the brunette. It wasn't very fruitful, but it wasn't a total bust either. At the very least, it spawned the idea that Max could use one of Chloe's many discarded school notebooks to write things out, since she was still having trouble talking.

The first thing she wrote was an apology. Actually, every other sentence either ended or began with an admission of guilt.

I'm sorry. I didn't write to you when I had the chance, and now that we're face to face it's all I can do.

I missed you so much. I'm sorry I never called. I should have done more.

Tell Joyce I said thanks for the pancakes. Sorry I couldn't finish it all.

They'd filled a few pages together, Chloe answering aloud and Max jotting everything down, a one-sided record of their conversation. And while she seemed to be in genuinely better spirits, she was on edge the whole time, shoulders raised and rigid, flinching at any and every little sound. The only thing that seemed to ease her mind was hearing mention of step-douche and his security guard gig, and Chloe can remember the way she rushed to scrawl out her reply.

I need to talk to him.

And that confused the hell out of her, sure, but Chloe certainly wasn't going to deny the request. Max had apparently been pretty adamant about staying away from the hospital, maybe she was just too scared to go to a real cop. So Chloe had sat idly by while Max spent a whole ass hour scribbling away in that notebook, writing and rewriting, scratching things out, hazy determination in her eyes. She didn't reveal what she wrote– not that Chloe wants to know that much anyway.

Okay, that's a lie. A bad one. She really fucking wants to know what the hell Max had written, because when step-dick came by to check on them during his lunch break and she handed him that neatly folded square of paper, his brows furrowed. And when he opened it up, when he got a glimpse of its contents, he went white as a sheet. And when he hurried back out the door, he did so clutching that little scrap of paper in his hand like a pinless grenade.

But Max had looked so relieved when she came back into the room without it, so Chloe swallowed the impulse to ask. Figuring they both needed a distraction, she offered to put on Blade Runner, like the old days.

Max had slid the notebook across the bed, opened to a fresh page adorned with the words, *How about Scooby-Doo? Like the really old days.*

Evidently, they both nodded off there, cuddled up on Chloe's bed with way, way too many blankets on. But what's a little discomfort to her when Max has been shivering with the consistency of a caffeinated chihuahua.

Humorous descriptions aside, it's hard to see her like this. Max, her Max, fucked up almost beyond recognition. Her best friend, her bright, energetic first mate, reduced to skin and bones and aching silence. When did she get so thin? When did her eyes become so haunted and hollow?

The sound of Max's body hitting the pavement plays over and over in the back of her head. The sight of her eyes rolled back, the pooling crimson on her teeth — on her lips, her chin, her shirt, everything — is burned into her brain. Chloe thought she was going to die. All of those years not seeing her, not hearing her,

missing her, and Max was going to die right there in her arms, gurgling blood and gasping for breath.

Max stirs a little, whimpers, tugs on the end of Chloe's shirt as she curls further in on herself.

Chloe pulls the blankets back over her shoulders, looks at the scratches and bruising on her freckled face, and comes to a chilling realization.

For nearly five years, she's been thinking the wrong thing. She thought that Max had abandoned her, left her to fend for herself. She thought that Max wasn't there for her, but it was just the opposite. She wasn't there for Max. She wasn't there to shield her from danger like a good captain should. She wasn't there to bandage the scrapes on her knees like she used to. She wasn't there to protect her from the sick bastard that hurt her.

She wasn't there, and now she's holding the ghost of a stranger.

Her blood boils beneath her skin, rage coursing through her like a venom and tightening each muscle it works through. She could hurt someone. Like, really hurt someone; take her trusty baseball bat and start bashing faces in until somebody fucking answers for this. She could tear this whole shitty town apart if it meant she'd be keeping Max out of harm's way. Whoever did this, they should consider themselves lucky that Chloe doesn't know.

"Easy, tiger." A familiar voice sends a shiver of surprise down Chloe's spine, and she cranes her neck to try and get a better look. "I can feel the murderous intent from here."

Rachel sits at her desk, one earbud in, chair pulled out to face them and a few loose sheets of homework spread out on the tabletop behind her.

"Shit, shit." Chloe scrambles to move without disturbing Max. "Is it that late already? Why didn't you wake me up?"

"Relax, it's only two o'clock."

That gets her attention. Chloe slips out of bed and onto her feet, unaware of the way Max whines at her absence.

"Dude, you're cutting class? Aren't you gonna get in trouble again?"

Rachel smiles, but not the wild, mischievous grin that Chloe was expecting. This smile is edgeless and plain, layered yet thin. An expertly tailored lie. "I'll burn that bridge when I get to it."

She hates it when Rachel feels the need to act around her.

To say they're close would be the understatement of the century. In their first week of knowing each other alone, they argued, flirted, set a fire, engaged in Shakespearean improv, shared long-held secrets and kissed several times. Not to mention the whole stabbing ordeal, shit like that bonds you for life. Three years later and they've only added to that ridiculous list of escapades, each one bringing them closer. She's been told countless times by countless people to be wary, that Rachel Amber is as fake as they come, but Chloe knows the truth. Chloe sees her. The *real* her.

So there's nothing that stings quite like being on the receiving end of Rachel's reflexive camouflage. Pissy or not, she's still got a promise to keep, and so wastes no time in calling her bluff.

"What's gotten into you?" she grumbles, narrowing her eyes and stepping closer. "You were griping about your perfect attendance just this morning."

Rachel rolls her eyes, lips twitching into a frown. She never likes being caught, even if she knows she needs to be. "I had to get out of there," she mutters, pulling out her other earbud and

reaching to scratch at her shoulder. “I figured you of all people would understand.”

Chloe doesn’t answer that, too distracted by the hints of cinnamon in the air. She steps closer still, laying a hand on the arm of the chair and leaning in to loom over Rachel like a dog appraising its meal. Her eyes are glassy. There’s a stain on her shirt collar.

“You smell like Fireball,” Chloe whispers, eyes hard.

“Don’t worry. I saved some for you.”

For a minute, they just stare at each other. Chloe, teeth grit and jaw set tight, daring Rachel to bend. Rachel, steadfast with a blank face, daring Chloe to break.

But for the first time in years, arguing doesn’t feel like a priority.

Chloe straightens back up with a sigh. “Good, I could use a fucking drink. Wait– you weren’t boozejacking yuppies in the park without me, were you?”

“God, no,” Rachel snorts. “I couldn’t pull that off on my own.” She nods towards her bag, haphazardly slung under the desk, wherein Chloe can see an all too telling red cap peeking out to greet her.

“Good. I don’t trust you alone out there with a flammable substance.”

“Shut up,” whines Rachel as she turns back around. “It was one fucking time. Are you ever gonna let me live that down?”

“Like hell I will. I’ll be using that against you for the rest of our lives.”

They trade the bottle back and forth for a bit, catching up on the comings and goings of each other's day in between sips. Chloe's stomach offers its complaint, none too pleased to be full of only pancakes and alcohol, but she ignores it in favor of chasing

her buzz. It isn't until her fourth swig that she really starts to feel it, warmth blooming in her throat as everything softens around the edges. She blinks down at the desk.

“I can't believe you're doing chem homework drunk,” she says, watching Rachel take a swig and press her pencil back to the paper.

“I dunno,” Rachel shrugs, scratching out an answer. “Sounds pretty believable to me.”

Chloe studies her for a minute. Her eyes are distant and unfocused, lustreless hazel accented by the smeared purpling just below. She holds herself rigid and hunched, a far cry from her usual perfect posture. Her voice still carries a measured, practiced quality to it, though far more subtle than mere moments ago. After knowing her for so long, it's easy for Chloe to tell that she's still hiding under one more mask.

The one she uses to hide from herself.

“You're tired,” Chloe says simply, putting a hand on Rachel's back.

“I'm fine.”

“Rach.” Chloe's voice softens into something more sombre. “You were up with me all night, you didn’t eat breakfast, and you had half a bottle of whiskey for lunch. You’re tired.”

Rachel keeps writing.

Chloe hauls the chair away from the desk, holding back a wince at the sound of it scraping across the floor. Rachel yelps in surprise, dropping her pencil but reaching out to claw in vain at her worksheets.

“What the fuck, Chloe–”

“Nope. You had your chance to come willingly, now I’m taking you by force.”

"Taking me where?"

Chloe circles around to grab her hands and pulls her to her feet before pointing to the TV. "You're gonna sit and watch cartoons with me, and you're gonna shut your brain off for a minute."

Brows furrowed, Rachel replies, "Isn't that what the Fireball is for?"

"Yeah, but trying to do homework is kind of cancelling it out."

That seems to do the trick. Rachel rolls her eyes again and gives a rather melodramatic sigh, but begrudgingly agrees. "Alright, alright. Just for a little bit."

Luckily, a little bit turns into twenty minutes, and twenty minutes turns into an hour. They're sitting next to each other on the floor, both leaned up against the bed. Rachel had hardly made it through a single episode when she started to nod off, now slumped over with her head on Chloe's shoulder.

If she tries hard enough, Chloe can almost pretend that everything is fine.

That things are peaceful. That Rachel is just tired from late night studying. That Max is just finally here for a visit. That they're just a group of normal, average teenagers spending a normal, average afternoon together under normal, average circumstances.

And for a minute, it feels nice. It feels right. It feels *good* to have both of her best friends by her side.

Then Max wakes up screaming.

Rachel shoots several feet into the air and Chloe hurries to stand, both breathing hard and letting slip a few expletives in the process.

She'd been worried about something like this ever since Max first tumbled out of bed this morning. And she was right to be. Whatever the girl had seen in her sleep, it seems it was far worse

this time around. She's so pale Chloe swears she can spot faint blue traces of the veins in her face. Her cry creaks and crackles into silence, and she grips the sheets with white-knuckle force.

Chloe is by her side in an instant, stumbling over herself to get the words out. "Max, hey, Max, it's okay. You're okay."

Max stares straight through her.

Definitely worse than this morning. Shit, shit, fuck.

"Max? It's just me. It's just Chloe."

She's breathing so fast, constriction audible in the way she wheezes through each inhale, and every inch of her trembles like a leaf holding on for dear life amidst a storm. She's going to pass out if she keeps going like this, but nothing Chloe says is getting through to her and she just keeps shaking, she's shaking so damn bad and Chloe needs to make it *stop*.

Her hands hover uselessly at her sides. "What do we do?" she whispers, eyes wide. "Fuck, Rachel, what do we do?"

Rachel — who's been standing there petrified with her chest heaving in shock for the last few seconds — comes back to her senses. She plops herself down beside Max on the bed, pries one of her hands from the blankets and holds it in both of hers. She may be the better of the two of them at thinking on her feet, but Chloe can still pick out the notes of fear and hesitance in her voice.

"You're– You're safe," she says, visibly struggling to keep her composure. "You're safe, we've got you. You just need to breathe. Here, I'll do it with you."

Awareness flashes in Max's eyes, and Chloe watches as it's eaten up by the fog of panic. Her stomach sinks.

"Can you feel that?"

Rachel holds the girl's hand to her chest, takes a deep, exaggerated breath. Max nods, a movement so small Chloe almost mistakes it for an involuntary twitch.

"Good. Try to match my pace, alright?"

She takes another breath, pointedly slow, holds it for a moment, and releases. Max screws her eyes shut and shivers through an attempt to mimic her. Nowhere near slow enough, but it's a start.

Chloe swallows the lump in her throat, the feeling of helplessness, and finally forces her limbs to move. She takes Max's other hand, holds it like it's made of glass, smooths her thumb over the girl's knuckles. She tries to keep pace with them, too. If not to steady her own nerves than to give Max more to latch onto.

"That's it, you're doing good. Just keep breathing with me, okay?"

Chloe tries not to think about the fact that Rachel has done this same song and dance with her on multiple occasions. She doesn't want to believe that Max could have panic attacks at all, let alone ones as bad hers or worse. Even if it's happening right in front of her.

Bits and pieces of her earlier dream trickle through her daze, her father's voice echoing in the back of her mind.

Hares are solitary creatures.

That's why they run.

She squeezes Max's hand. The words spill out before she can register what they are. "You don't have to keep running."

Rachel throws her a questioning glance and Chloe answers it with a shrug of equal confusion, but they both snap their attention back to Max as her small, scared voice comes to haunt the space between them.

"P-Promise?"

"Yeah." Chloe's own voice cracks as she replies without missing a beat. "Of course."

And then Max is crying, but her breathing finally starts to even out and some of the tension shudders away from her, so it's overall an improvement. When she opens her eyes they're still blown wide in fear, and her gaze darts about the room in a rush, settling first on Chloe, and then on Rachel's hands pressed against hers.

Rachel gives a shaky, apologetic smile and moves to let her go. Max keeps her hand right where it is overtop the rise and fall of the blonde's chest, watching the movement in rapt silence. Her fingers twitch as if to hold tight.

Voice somewhere between horror and awe, Rachel murmurs, "We should… We should get her some water."

"Right." Chloe can hear herself talking, but she feels millions of miles away from the conversation. "I'm on it. Be right back." She nearly twists her ankle in her mad dash down the stairs, but it doesn't phase her. There are far more pressing matters at hand.

Fuck. Holy fuck. Holy goddamn fucking fuck, what the hell happened to Max? She has to get that note back from David. She has to know what's going on. She *has* to.

Chloe grabs a water bottle with near lethal force, and resigns herself to the fact that she'll be in jail for murder by the end of the week.

Somehow, things calm down after that. They coax Max through a few sips and convince her to lay back down, though she keeps the hem of Rachel's flannel clutched in a death grip. Rachel doesn't seem to mind at least. She stays by Max's side and keeps offering gentle reassurances, just like she does for Chloe.

Max falls asleep halfway through a rasping apology, and with a shock of dread Chloe realizes that the choked, hiccuping cries she hears are coming from her own mouth.

"C'mere," Rachel calls to her, patting the empty space beside her. There's a strange sort of look in her eyes, smoldering embers of something sharp, something wrathful. "And bring the Fireball."

Chloe sniffles, rushes to rub at her eyes with her sleeves. When she sits on the edge of the bed with whiskey in hand, her movements are stilted and robotic. "All yours," she croaks, handing the bottle over. "I'm gonna stay– One of us should– Just in case, y'know?"

Rachel nods, a pensive frown adorning her features. She reaches out to lay a hand on Chloe's, keeping the other wrapped tight around the neck of the bottle. "You gonna be alright?"

"Yeah," Chloe breathes, gaze fixed on Max's sleeping form.

"You sure?"

"… Yeah. Thanks, by the way."

"Okay." Rachel takes another swig, glances down at Max's face. "Turn up the talking dog. We both need to shut our brains off."

Chloe obliges with an absentminded hum, and they lapse into relative silence.

She stays quiet when Rachel falls asleep there, half propped up against the wall with an expression more reminiscent of when she'd been laid up in a hospital bed, slipping the Fireball from her slackening grip and placing it back on the floor. She stays quiet when her mother comes home alone, merely refusing the offer of dinner with a quick shake of her head. She stays quiet as the hours trickle by, sky darkening outside her window, the only sound in the house being the muted guitars of the DVD menu music that's been looping for the past few minutes. She doesn't get up to

change the disc, too afraid of what might happen if she turns her back on either of them for even a second. The universe seems dead set on trying to take them from her, after all.

Despite the combined efforts of adrenaline and her earlier nap, Chloe too drifts in and out of sleep, only blinking back to awareness at the sound of boots on the stairs, the floorboards outside her door groaning in protest to them.

"Chloe."

She's never heard step-douche speak so quietly. Chloe raises her head, making a muttered noise of acknowledgement and trying to shake the fuzz from her vision. A glimpse at her phone tells her that it's far, far past his usual late working hours.

Unease chases the drowsiness away. Chloe moves aside, gestures to the girl curled up behind her. David lets out a sigh of relief.

"Oh, thank Christ," he says on the exhale. "You– You keep an eye on her, alright?"

Maybe under different circumstances, Chloe would sound defensive when she says, "I always do." But right now, she can hear the way her voice bends and breaks around the sentiment, nausea rising in her throat. "Why?" she asks, soft and subdued. "What's going on?"

David looks away. "Your friend," he answers, his face cycling through a manic mix of anger and terror and gratitude. "When she wakes up, you tell her we're gonna get that son of a bitch."

chained to the weight

Victoria doesn’t know where Nathan is.

She never does, but each time they have this conversation, she's a little softer. A little more raw, vulnerable. It only makes things harder.

Max sees her with paint on her cashmere, with tape around her wrists.

It's her fault Victoria ended up down there, that first time. Down in the Dark Room with *him*, doomed to die scared and alone. It's all her fault, always her fault. She keeps getting people hurt. She keeps getting people *killed*.

If only Max hadn't opened her big mouth.

Thrumming bass fades into gentle birdsong. As her eyes flutter open, Max becomes aware of two things.

Her skull splitting headache has downgraded to a muted, omnipresent throb; and she's woken up in a thousand degree pile of limbs.

She could have sworn she was back at that Vortex Club party. The neon lights, the booming speakers, the mixture of pity and disbelief in Victoria's eyes. Her ears are still ringing.

Or maybe it *was* just a dream. It's hard to tell the difference, sometimes.

It’s part of the reason why resting is so low on her list of priorities. As she’s come to learn over the course of her many cycles, any form of unconsciousness is simply an excuse for her mind to drag her into a muddled labyrinth of moments past. She already has enough memories to parse through on a daily basis. Places, dates, times, the best answers to any given question, the quickest way to persuade someone. And the dreams — flashbacks, nightmares, whatever you want to call them — serve no greater purpose outside of jump-starting her into a delirious frenzy. She'll startle from one vision to find herself in another, and then another, repeating ad nauseam until she's never quite sure if anything she's doing is real or if she's just yet to wake up back at the beginning again.

Then again, sometimes that part is a dream too.

Thankfully, there's a blonde, flannel clad reality-check snoring away next to her. That alone makes the rest of her attempt to re-orient herself far more effective than normal. It makes the whens and wheres easier, at least.

A fresh cycle — the last, with any luck — somewhere in the vicinity of morning. She's still in Chloe's room, and however long she's been out, it's *too* long.

She pulls her arm out of the Rachel and Chloe sandwich it was trapped between, untangles her legs from theirs and worms her way out of all the blankets. Chloe gives a small noise of protest at all the movement, but ultimately just rolls over and nuzzles further into Rachel, who answers by sleepily slinging an arm over her back. They’re all wrapped up in each other like a pair of koalas, impossibly close and entirely unwilling to let go. It would

be cute if it weren't so heavily outweighed by the tarred, lingering thoughts of Chloe tipping over the cliff side, of Rachel's body in the junkyard.

Max tears her gaze away, forces herself to stand.

Now she needs to figure out the whats. What feels better, what still hurts. What she's already done and what she has to do next.

Her joints are sort of creaky, sort of crunchy, and very unwilling to listen to her. Her neck in particular has a lot of complaints, of the searing and aching variety. The pain flares out in thin, angry tendrils along her upper back, and Max finds herself with a new and far more literal understanding of the phrase ‘death by a thousand cuts.‘ But it’s fine. It’s not stopping her from moving, so it isn’t bad enough to worry about.

She knows she got Chloe to hand over the warning letter, and that's at least some of the Atlas burden eased from her shoulders. She's come to appreciate David Madsen, in an odd, knight-in-rusted-armor sort of way. She still considers him deserving of the step-douche moniker, but he's there for her when it matters most. He always believes her, and he always comes to rescue her from the Dark Room. Plus he’ll have much higher chances of convincing the police. She trusts that he'll handle Jefferson.

That leaves her to handle everything else. Only problem being that 'everything else' changed drastically the moment she rewound passed October. None of her insider knowledge or pinpoint predictions will be of much use for another few months, and still they may be worthless in the face of the alterations she’s setting in motion. For the first time in ages, she has no idea what's coming. To top it all off, the storm is liable to rear its ugly head at any given moment, seeing as inconsistence is one of its few consistencies. It's all equal parts peculiar and terrifying.

More terrifying, however, is facing her reflection.

She looks… Well, to put it politely she looks like she's been backed over by Frank's RV. More than once. Also, her hair is a good few inches longer than it should be, which is not going to be easy to explain away.

To put it less politely, she looks like a fucking drowned raccoon.

The bags under her eyes are nothing new, they've been there since the first days and have been the only thing to truly stay with her every time, but they certainly don't help the whole washed-up animal vibe she has going on. The results of her exponentially weakening appetite stare back at her in the form of sunken cheeks and a jawline more reminiscent of a switchblade. And of course, the aforementioned problem of her hair, bedraggled and scruffy and nothing resembling the semi-neat bob she'd been wearing it in.

No wonder Victoria's been going easy on her the last few rounds. She's a walking trainwreck and anyone could see it in a single glance.

After splashing some water on her face and dutifully avoiding another glance in the mirror, Max decides her first order of business is to come up with a plausible explanation for herself. People are just going to keep asking, and the time limit for her parents' frantic arrival in Arcadia Bay is probably already ticking down. Maybe she could string a few arrant details into a somewhat coherent story. Maybe she could convince her parents to just let her stay since she'll be enrolled in Blackwell come September anyhow.

Is running off to live in the woods an option?

Probably not. Not a smart one, anyways, but Max keeps the idea in her back pocket nonetheless.

She stays out in the hallway for a bit, shambling from end to end under the notion that she does her best thinking when she's pacing, though she soon gains the courage to try and trot downstairs. On second thought, hubris might be a better word. Joyce was right, stairs are no good, no fun, very bad. Still, she pushes through it. Dizziness will fade. Pain will subside. She might not ever get another chance like this, so she has to make the best of it.

There's a note left on the kitchen table, though judging from a quick skim of its contents it wasn't meant for her. The bottle of acetaminophen and the candy bar sitting next to it, on the other hand. It's sweet of Joyce to remember her favorite junk food after all these years, but Max passes over it in favor of dry-swallowing two pills. She doubts they'll do much to aid a chronic, time-travel induced migraine, but it's worth a shot.

She just needs to clear her head and get started on a plan. Get back up and get running. She had a dream last night about being told that she could slow down, and she knows it must have been a dream because such foolish optimism could only be the product of fantasy. The longer she stays still, the less she'll want to move, and she can't stop. Even if she wants to.

She doesn’t get very far in her plotting on account of the fact that fate has other ideas for her.

First comes the muffled shout of, "Dude, get *up*, c'mon."

Quickly followed by the sound of Chloe's bedroom door crashing open.

"Jesus, what time is it?"

"Max? Max, where'd you go?"

And she tries to call out an answer, but her stupid voice still refuses to come out at anything above a murmur and she can picture the way Chloe is about to rush down the stairs, trip and sprain her ankle or something. Probably because it happened once before when they were younger. Between that and her tendency to do things without thinking whenever she hears Chloe talking in that frantic, distressed tone, Max rewinds without hesitation.

It's still a fraction of what it used to be, but she can't help the spark of excitement when she manages to turn back a far more substantial amount of time than her last attempt. She might just lose it altogether if her powers don't fully recover. Somehow they are both the reason she’s unravelling and the final thread she clings to.

Maybe she moves a bit too fast but she makes it to the bottom of the stairs as the door slams open again, just in time to see Chloe stumbling into the hall with a decidedly groggy Rachel trailing behind her. They've both got bedhead to rival her own, and it looks like they fell asleep in whatever they'd been wearing yesterday.

"Jesus, what time is it?"

"Max? Max, where'd you–"

"Hi," Max waves up at them, holding back a wince at the pitiful sound of her greeting.

Rachel squints down at her like she's trying to figure out a calculus equation and Chloe heaves a sigh, running a hand through her bangs.

"Fuck, you scared the shit outta me, man. Are you okay? What are you doing down there?"

Alarm bells sound off. More questions to duck and weave her way around. Max isn't sure if this whole situation has made her better or worse at thinking on the spot, but she does know that

lying to and/or hiding things from Chloe is never easy. Even if it's safer that way, even if it's necessary, and evidently even when put in a position that literally prevents her from saying too much, very rarely does she find it in herself to follow through with the dishonesty.

"M'fine. Wanted to get moving." A coherent sentence, at least.

Chloe opens and closes her mouth a few times as if struggling to process the words.

Rachel makes an expression of complete and utter bemusement. "You're fucking nuts," she says to Max, before turning to Chloe and gesturing down the stairs in a huff. "Chloe, she's fucking nuts."

"*Rachel*," Chloe whisper-shouts, elbowing her in the side

"What? Can you tell me I'm wrong?" Rachel elbows her back. "If I were her I'd be in bed the whole damn week."

"Dude, be nice."

"This *is* nice for hungover me and you know it."

Max lets out a laugh, small and half choked, but a laugh nonetheless. They bicker like Joyce and William used to. Just with a lot more cussing and gratuitous use of the word, 'dude.'

Max remembers finding the picture of Rachel in Chloe's room, how she'd scrambled to take it, to hold it close. The shirts hung up beside hers in the closet. The writing on the wall in the junkyard shack. The way Chloe's eyes softened as she said, "*She was my angel*."

"What's so funny?" they both splutter, just the slightest bit off-time, before eyeing each other and devolving into their own distinct flavors of flustered.

And oh, what rib shaking elation rattles through her at the sight of it. Liquid sunlight shot straight through her veins, straw-

berry lightning fizzling through each strained, twitching muscle of her heart. Happiness is foreign to her at this point, and therefore just as likely to cloud her judgement as carnal anxiety or blind anguish.

She rewinds so she can see it again.

And again. And then she holds a preemptive sleeve over her nose and says, "Nothing."

Just happy to see you stays stuck in her throat.

Common sense taps her on the shoulder and reminds her that she's still wearing one of Rachel's sweaters and probably shouldn't be so careless with it. Not to mention she really doesn't want either of them to see or deal with this more than they've already had to. She can take care of it herself. So she slips back to the kitchen without another word, wrestles her way out of the sweater and grabs a fistful of paper towel.

What was it Joyce had told her to do? Lean forward and pinch her nostrils shut?

They find her half bent over the sink, and though she doesn't turn to see them Max points in what she thinks is the direction of the discarded item of clothing and mutters, "Sorry if I got blood on it." Which was a mistake, because her headache spikes and she can feel the blood trickling down over her mouth and boy does she miss when this bullshit wasn't a part of her day to day routine.

For a minute, no one says anything.

Then, Chloe scoffs. "Max, you're fucking nuts. Who cares about the sweater, it's in better shape than you are. Should I–"

"S'fine," Max mutters, against her better judgement. "It'll… stop… in a minute."

Each pause is accented by a dripping sound. It would almost be comical if it weren't for, well, everything about it. She's going to have to get better at rationing both her words and her rewinds.

"You say that like this is a regular thing for you."

Rachel's voice is deeper than Max thought it would be, and she doesn't know if she'll ever quite get used to it. In a good way, of course. Sweet, mellifluous honey, a distinct air of certainty dipped in softness. Nothing her imagination came up with could compare to actually hearing it, and when Max cleans herself off and actually faces her, it's like staring into the blinding core of a star. The already loose thought of curbing her answers burns up in the light.

"Kinda."

This earns a raised eyebrow from Chloe, though her subsequent incredulous query of, "Since when?" is interrupted by Rachel handing her the note from the table.

She's no less blinding to look at. There's the simmering relief of seeing her alive and well again, but there's also a veritable cocktail of grief, longing, guilt and adoration that roils in Max's chest each time their eyes meet. She feels simultaneously sick and cured, lost and found. It all swells to a scalding, saccharine crescendo, and the joy of being by her side wins out over everything else like it does every time.

Maybe she *could* stop. Just for a second. Just to look at them a little more.

Because what has she been working for, what has she been suffering for, what has she torn herself apart for if not to see them live?

"Yo, earth to Max." She blinks, and finds Chloe has gotten close enough to lay a hand on her arm. "You need to sit down or something? You're spacing out hardcore."

Just for a second, Max tells herself.

Classes are cancelled for the day, according to the note Joyce left, and Max tries to not to show the full depth of her solace. She merely nods along to the offer of food and basks in the weight of their presence. She has to enjoy these moments of relative peace while she has them. They're part of what makes the struggle so worthwhile.

It turns out Rachel is one of those 'don't talk to me until I've had my coffee' types. She keeps that grumpy slouch in her posture until she's halfway through the cup, after which she brightens considerably and offers her gratitude with a satisfied grin. Chloe smiles too, and god is it a sight for sore eyes.

"Ah, there she is," she chuckles, reaching over to ruffle Rachel's hair, eyes lit soft and warm with mirth.

"I never left, you dweeb," Rachel answers, playfully swatting the girl's hand away.

Max has to be careful, or she'll be tempted to stop and stare forever.

There's something up with Max Caulfield.

And no, it's not just the fact that she's clearly fucked in the head from whatever she's gone through. Although it certainly is a contributing factor.

Rachel has a growing list of oddities to file away for later dissection. For starters, she sure is bright eyed and bushy tailed for someone whose sole comfort was the promise of slowing down. Actually, she doesn't seem to even remember any of what went down, or if she does then she hasn't brought it up at all. Rachel

wouldn't blame her either way, but it's still getting added to the list.

Then, there's the follow up issue of what the hell is going with her. Like, physically. Rachel's best hazarded guess is a concussion, but even if correct it still raises more questions than answers. And it bears repeating that, "*Wanted to get moving,*" is not the normal thought process of someone who should probably be in the hospital. Speaking of, Max is the only one who *isn't* freaked out by the nosebleeds, which is one part impressive and two parts absurd. If anything she almost looks annoyed by them. Which sort of implies that she knows what's causing them? Maybe?

Some other choice picks include: her uncanny sense of timing appearing at the bottom of the stairs this morning, the 'I know what you did last summer' stare that remains steadfast in her every expression, the way her pupils dilated with want as she attempted not to look like she was eyeing their cigarettes. Chloe might not have noticed that last one on account of the joint they'd shared a few moments before, but Rachel knows that look when she sees it.

Oh, and there's also the itty bitty conundrum of Max's mere presence in Arcadia Bay flipping the entirety of Blackwell on its head.

By the time Rachel actually thinks to swing back upstairs and grab her phone, she has — and this is only a slight exaggeration — about a hundred unread messages and missed calls. The vast majority of them come from her father, but there are also quite a few updates and questions and even goddamn pictures from various other students to scroll through. Oh joy.

First, the voicemails. Rachel's relationship with her father isn't perfect. It hasn't been for a long time now, hence her staying in the dorms as of late. But it's there. It's something. They aren't openly

hostile with each other, but she isn't his little girl anymore either, and he's well aware.

Still, most of the messages she listens to consist of two questions. Where are you, are you okay. He even made a point to reiterate several times over how she won't be in any trouble for missing class or curfew, that he just wants to know that she's safe. Which is… she's going to need more coffee before she unpacks that. And she hasn't even gotten to the texts yet.

Those are the *real* treasure trove of fuckery. All caps rambles and paragraphs of groupchat speculation, blurry shots of cop cars in the school lot and of course, the same gossipy summary of events that holds no real information copy-and-pasted anywhere and everywhere, no doubt courtesy of one Victoria Chase.

In short, shit is fucking whack and it all started when Max quite literally fell into her life.

Figuring it's best to get it over with sooner rather than later, Rachel takes a deep breath and calls her father.

He picks up before the first ring has finished. "Rachel, are you alright? Do you know how worried I've been?"

She doesn't like where this is going.

"Dad," she says, because she knows it'll get his attention. "What's going on? Everybody's freaking out and I can't get a straight answer out of anyone."

Her father sighs in the long, drawn out fashion that suggests he doesn't want to tell her. But he knows better by now.

"Mark Jefferson was arrested early this morning."

She *really* doesn't like where this is going.

"They found some– they found some disturbing things of his, and the school said you missed your afternoon classes, and you wouldn't answer your phone, and–"

"Slow down." It's been a while since she's heard him so out of sorts. Not since the whole emergency surgery debacle. "What did they find?"

Silence, sharp and taut.

"Dad, what did they find. I can handle it."

His next words are muffled and dim, like he's holding the phone away from his face in an attempt to keep her from hearing. "And what if I can't?"

She would be lying if she said that didn't elicit even the tiniest prick of dread in the pit of her stomach. He doesn't speak of his cases very often, and even more seldom still does he let on just how much they can bother him.

She hears the disgust constricting around his tone like a python.

"…Photo albums."

Rachel swallows. As morbid as it is, she saw that part coming.

"He had– It–" a stuttered inhale, an exhausted sigh. "One of them had your name on the cover."

Jefferson's wide, wolfy grin flashes in her mind. *There's my star student* .

She doesn't register much of what her father says after that. She catches, "empty, thank Christ," and "we need you to come home tonight," but that's about it. She says yes, probably. It's kind of hard to stay rooted in the present under the looming crisis that sort of revelation causes.

But who needs to be in the present anyways? This present moment fucking *sucks* .

Running through a montage of past encounters like the world's most insidious clip-show isn't all that much better, though. She almost wishes she could just shed her skin and exorcise every

smile, every touch, every word from her body. Seriously, what kind of fucked up serial killer bullshit? It's like something out of a goddamn horror movie.

She used to like him. She thought he was witty, charming, one of the only fun members of Blackwell faculty. She looked forward to photography class. She joined other students in praising his work, both as a teacher and as an artist, countless times.

She was almost a trophy on his wall.

An empty photo album, all for her.

No, albums. Plural. Is there…

Is there one for Max?

Is it full?

She keeps her phone in a death grip as she drifts back downstairs, though it goes unnoticed in the mire of questions crawling their way up from the more cataclysmic corners of her mind. She hardly hears the sound of Chloe's voice over the maelstrom. There are still a thousand things about this entire situation that don't make sense, but one thing is plain to see.

Rachel didn't dodge a bullet.

There's a half dead, half feral hare of a girl in the kitchen who ripped herself out of the rusting maw of a beartrap and took the bullet for her.

And what a strange feeling it is — how spine-chilling, how leaden and grave — to look upon a wounded creature and know it bled for your sake. To see the gashes running deep and long through its flesh and know they could have been your own. To peer into its darkened eyes and wonder how hard it fought just to fall limp at your feet.

"What's on the go, Rach?" Chloe asks, drawing her from her doom spiral, if only slightly. "You were up there for a while."

"I need another smoke," she answers, distracted and distant. Without sparing it a second thought, she adds, "Max, do you want one?"

The name rolls off her tongue like molten ore, white-hot richness scorching down her jaw and branding her indebted to its owner.

"Fucking hello?" Chloe balks at the offer, her face the very picture of disbelief.

Max gives a shy nod.

"Fucking *hello*?" Chloe says again, somehow even more gob-smacked than the first time, looking between them in frantic confusion.

"It's fine, Chloe," Rachel dismisses with a shrug, tearing her gaze away and stepping out of sight. Then, sotto voce, a sentiment simmering and secretive and all her own, "She can have whatever the hell she wants."

The shock doesn't falter from Chloe's expression the entire time they're out. The dubious furrow of her brows tells Rachel that this should be a first, but Max lights up and takes a long, slow drag with all the ease and nonchalance of a pro. Even the way her posture slackens on the exhale is indicative of habit.

Rachel makes a note of it. For the list. Because nothing — no chaotic butterfly, no desperate hare — escapes her curiosity.

They're quiet, for a little while. Long enough for her to both debate and decide on having another cigarette, but by that point Chloe looks like she's going to spontaneously combust with questions. In all honesty, Rachel is surprised neither of them have completely lost the plot with everything that's happened, though there's probably something to be said about the wonders of mixing weed and emotional shock. But the numbness won't last. She can

already feel it fading, strips of veneer peeling away into something tender and raw.

And, as a shiver claws its way through her, Rachel stops, and stares, and allows herself to ponder the catastrophic what-ifs that her chain smoking has failed to quell.

What if she had taken Jefferson up on one of his offers? Would she have accepted without a second thought, wearing her foolish, prideful smile and following along like a lamb for slaughter?

What if she never came back? If that moment of ever optimistic hubris had proved to be her last, would it be all she's remembered for? Walking herself into the mouth of danger?

What if Max hadn't made it to her in time? What if she had never made it at all, if she hadn't warned Rachel to stay as far from Jefferson as she could. Would Chloe ever find out what happened? Would she wind up all alone when Rachel inevitably disappeared too?

The most cavernous of all her questions creeps cold and venomous along her spine, settles in her rib cage and makes a home for itself in the uneasy pulsing of her heart.

What if she never saw Chloe again?

No more goofy grins or raucous laughter. No more bumping shoulders or lacing hands. No more midnight joyrides or backseat therapy sessions. She would never hear that voice, guarded to all else and softened just for her, bearing whispered comforts and clumsily declared affections, the way it curls around her name in bright sprawls of rose and ivy. She would never feel that warmth, the euphoria of waking up tangled in one another, the pleasant shiver of familiar fingers ghosting over the contours of her tattoo.

That above all else, even the thought of her own potential untimely demise, is what scares her. Being torn away from her

sun, her moon, her stars. Being torn away from the only thing that matters.

But you haven't been, Rachel reminds herself, nearly choking on an inhale in the process. *She's here, you're here, everything is fine.*

Suddenly, the notion of spending the night apart is less a normal, temporary inconvenience and more a Herculean endeavor. For now, she shuffles closer, busies herself with picking out the different shades of blue in the blend of Chloe's hair. She really likes it blue. She should say so more often.

So she does, completely aware it's coming out of left field and not caring one bit. "Your hair is so pretty," she sighs, and her voice sounds wrong even to her; tired, thin.

Max nods sagely and murmurs, "Hella pretty."

And even amidst the hurricane of overthinking, how could she not laugh at that? This girl is full of surprises, it seems. The fact that Chloe looks utterly bewildered by the both of them only adds to the unintentional humor.

"You didn't strike me as the hella type," she comments on the tailend of a breathy chuckle. "Where'd you pick that up?"

Max's tentative little smile falters, for a fraction of a second. Her eyes glint cautious and secretive in the sunlight.

"A friend."

For someone who will forever go down in Blackwell history for being a mediocre actress, Chloe thinks she's doing a pretty good job of acting like she hasn't totally lost her fucking marbles.

She even managed to (mostly) hold her tongue when Max had a smoke with them, even if just the thought of it is so many levels of bonkers that it borders on sacrilege. No, actually, what the hell

went down in Seattle and what lanky skeeve of a hipster does Chloe have to punch out for giving the girl her first cigarette?

Other than that she's doing a better job keeping her cool than Rachel, which is ass backwards and more than a little concerning. But she isn't sure how to bring it up without letting on to the aforementioned problem of her lost marbles, on account of the hushed, horrific conversation she had with step-douche last night in the hall.

For once, he was forthcoming, and for once, Chloe was almost sort of grateful for his lack of boundaries.

He said that everything in Max's note was accurate, and then proceeded to divulge half its contents. The location, the setup, the assortment of vials and syringes, the shelf full of neatly arranged 'photo albums' hand labeled with the name of each girl found within. Every little thing, down to the chilling detail that there would be no evidence of her being there, was true. Including the part about the freak behind it all having eyes for Rachel. And that sure elicited some genuine, seething disgust, but then he told her about the empty album with Rachel's name on it, and *that* created the odd marriage of stone cold fear and boiling rage that she's currently muddled in.

Oh, and the freak in question is one of their fucking teachers.

Really, how is she supposed to cope with the knowledge that Rachel was inches from someone so dangerous practically every day? Or the idea that Max spent enough time in this dude's murder basement that she could commit so many details to memory? Or the fact that she herself has walked right past him on several occasions without sparing a second glance?

Somehow, she's managing. Or at least managing to keep herself balanced between two high density emotions to the point of

void-like equilibrium. That counts as being calm, right? It's gonna have to for now, because if the scales tip in either direction she can't guarantee she won't just default to blowing up at the first person who speaks to her. And she can't imagine either Rachel or Max are in the market to be on the losing end of her temper.

So keeps herself taut and rigid and vehemently steers herself away from the darker thoughts. She doesn't show her disappointment when Rachel mutters about James wanting her home after the fifth ignored call in a half-hour span — of course he already knows, and with her rampant curiosity surely Rachel will too by the end of the night — even if it takes what little wind had been in her sails. She keeps her what the hell's and why the hell's under trembling lock and key, no matter how they keep piling up. She holds the white-water crush of panic at bay, despite the force of the tidal wave.

But then, it appears. The final straw.

After Rachel's grumbling and reluctant departure, Max had been fidgeting with her hair. Chloe had offered to grab her something to wear while she hopped in the shower. All well and good, normal as can be for the situation they're in. The problem arises from two key factors. First, Max's ruffled mane has gone limp from the water, no longer so obscuring as it had been. Second, due to their height difference, all of Chloe's shirts are super loose on Max, especially around the collar. So when she shuffles out in that egregiously baggy Fire Walk t-shirt and Chloe catches a glimpse of her from the back, the sag of the fabric and the part of hair reveals a monstrous patch of scarring trailing down Max's neck.

"Max," she chokes out, "What the fuck is that?"

She's moving before she can think it through, coming up behind the girl and reaching to tug the shirt collar aside. A myriad of

reddened indentations greet her, stark against Max's pale skin and billowing into a great latticework of marring. It almost looks like lightning, branching out thinner and thinner with every splicing strike, all stemming from a single blotch of a scar scorched into the nape of her neck.

As previously stated: What. The. Fuck.

Max flinches away from her. "Fell. Probably."

Chloe can practically feel the rationality leaving her, instantaneous and reverberating like a guitar string snapping mid-pluck. "Dude, I know you can't see it, but there's no fucking way you got this from falling. When the hell did this happen?"

"Dunno."

"Is there anything you do know?" Chloe winces at her harsh tone, but now that she's lost her grip there's nothing she can do to stop the words from spilling out. "Cause I've been trying to figure out what to fucking *do* about all of this and I just– I need you to *tell me*, Max. Something, anything. Please."

There's a moment's silence wherein Max winds tense, wrapping her arms around herself. Chloe watches the way she digs her nails into her arms. "Can't."

"Why the fuck not?"

"...Wouldn't believe me."

"Like hell I wouldn't," she snaps, because she never once thought about how monumentally it would suck to know Max felt that way. "Try me."

By the look of that thing she could say she was mauled by a t-rex and Chloe would believe it no question. She just needs to know what the fuck is going on so she can figure out how to help.

But Max just shakes her head, her voice cracking under its own weight when she says, "Don't want you to get hurt."

And that's even harder to swallow, considering she's the one who came limping back into Chloe's life looking more like roadkill than the goofy kid she'd last been. But she was always the type to worry about others first. There was one instance back in the day where they'd gotten a little too rambunctious in their gallivanting and taken a bit of a tumble, and Chloe can still remember the way Max had gotten up first, scrambled to her side and held out a scraped, bruising hand to help her back to her feet.

"I won't." Chloe lets out a sigh, wills the adrenaline to melt. It stays unfortunately solid. "Step-douche said they're gonna put that guy away. He won't hurt anyone anymore."

She hates the way Max cringes at the mere allusion.

Another frantic shake of her head. "Not just him. Me."

All things considered, it isn't very loud, but it's the most volume she's managed as of recent, and that's enough to make Chloe jump.

Max finally turns to show her glassy, faraway gaze. "I get *everyone* hurt." Her breath comes quick and shallow, and blood begins to drip from her nose as she adds a bitter, breaking, "I always do. I always do."

"Shit, Max, You're–"

"Don't. It's– It's okay. M'sorry." She rushes to cover herself up, takes a few timid steps away. Then, a hissed aside, "You're doing it again. Bad Max. Can't you get anything right?"

Okay. Okay okay okay, crisis mode activated.

"Hey." Chloe stops her before she can apologize again. If you'd asked her a week ago she would have wanted an apology, but now each one she hears is more akin to swallowing glass. “Dude, slow down.”

“I *can’t*,” Max croaks, eyes wide and wild and dire in a way that sends uncanny sparks of deja-vu prickling through Chloe's veins. “If I slow down I’ll lose you again n’ I can’t– can’t fix anything like this, I can’t, so I won’t lose you again, gotta keep going so I don’t lose you–”

Chloe does the only thing she can think to do. She closes their distance, takes Max’s face in both hands — gently, so goddamn gently, more gentle than she’s ever been in her entire life — tilts it up and tries her best not to focus on the blood. “*Max*. Max, look at me. I’m right here, you aren’t gonna lose me.”

"But–"

"No buts." She tightens her grip, half-consciously strokes a thumb over her cheek. "I'm fine, see? I don't know where your head is taking you, but you gotta come back."

Max looks up at her, sombre and knowing, heavy and hopeless, before relenting with a choked little whimper. She shuts her eyes, lets slip a few silent tears, leans into Chloe's hand and fights her way through an exhale.

And god, she seems even smaller like this.

Small, brittle, and long since shattered.

"Still with me?" A weak nod. "Good. C'mon, let's get your nose taken care of."

Though Chloe has to practically drag her back to the bathroom sink, once they get there she's quick to regain her earlier reluctance and insists on doing everything herself. Even with her hands shaking. She stays doubled over with all of her weight held on one arm in spite of the way it visibly protests the strain, and Chloe finds herself taking the opportunity to try and look at that– that *thing*, whatever it is.

It sort of reminds her of a lichtenberg figure, but she's almost positive that they don't stick around very long. Nor do they look so much like carved trails through the skin. She tries to imagine what could have caused it, what it must have felt like, visceral unease growing with each centimeter she takes in. She hasn't even seen it in full. She doesn't know if she wants to.

The question comes cautious, hushed, and guilty. "Does it hurt?"

Max goes stock still. Chloe can see the debate swirling in her eyes through the mirror. "…A little."

"What can I do?"

Chloe isn't sure what she's expecting, maybe a refusal, maybe a shrug, maybe no answer at all. What she gets is confessional and dim. What she gets is burdened beyond comprehension.

What she gets is muted conviction.

"Tell me I can do this," Max whispers, watching diluted crimson wash down the drain. "Tell me I won't fuck it up."

Fuck what up ? Chloe wants to ask, because every word out of the girl's mouth is making less and less sense, and the levels of concern have gone from frankly insane to downright astronomical in proportion. Instead, she falls back on tried and true reassurance from their younger days, familiar words bubbling up from somewhere far brighter than here and now.

"You got this, Max. You'll figure it out. You always do."

True, it usually came about in relation to math homework or some other mundanity, but recognition shows itself in the slow deflation of her posture. For a moment she seems like she's calmed down.

It doesn't last as long as it should.

She sort of squares herself up, fumbles through finishing cleaning off her face and does not startle the same way Chloe does at the sound of the front door opening downstairs, the voice calling out to them from below.

"Girls? I'm back."

Shit. Is it that late already?

She looks at Max as if to ask, *are you up for this?* Max gives her a nod in return, eyes half steeled and half corroded.

"In here, mom," Chloe calls out as she opens the door, and her mother is already in the process of rushing up the stairs to greet them.

"Max, honey, how are you feeling? I've got your mother on the phone, she really wants to talk to you."

It feels a little weird to argue against that, but after what she just caused and witnessed Chloe isn't sure a lengthy conversation of any kind is a good idea, no matter the other participant. "I don't know," she starts to say, only to be halted by a small tug on her sleeve.

"S'okay," Max assures, in that same stiff, resigned tone. Chloe doesn't miss the shudder that rolls through her thin frame as she takes the phone from Joyce's hand. For someone who's been through some unspeakably whack-ass traumatic shit and wound up far from home, she really doesn't look happy to hear from her parents.

Chloe was fully prepared to follow alongside her, were it not for the disapproving look sent her way.

"Give them a minute," her mother says in a murmur, tone weary and warning.

So she winds up waiting outside her room, leaned up against the wall with her arms crossed and mind running a thousand

miles a minute. She's not trying to eavesdrop or anything, she just can't shake the worry that if Max starts panicking again she'll lose half her blood content and they'll finally have to give in and send her off in an ambulance. Still, she can't help but overhear the odd word. As the minutes tick by in fitful, agonizing anticipation, an odd word turns into several; steadily growing in raspy volume. Several turns into something Chloe thought impossible, and as it dawns on her what's going on she almost can't believe what she's hearing.

Max is arguing with her mom.

They're fucking *arguing*.

Each sentence she catches is half a growl, raw and scratchy, brimming with frustration so thoroughly unlike anything she's ever heard from Max's mouth. Underneath it all lurks the unmistakable lilt of bone-deep exhaustion.

"Doesn't matter."

"I can look after myself."

"Can't make me."

"I– I don't fucking *care*. M'not going."

And holy shit, she did not just drop an f-bomb on her mom. That's like, the third law of the universe. Conservation of mass, equal and opposite reactions, don't curse in front of Vanessa Caulfield if you want to live. In fact, Chloe is so floored by this that she doesn't clue in to the ensuing scuffling, the sound of paper tearing, the grating slide of vinyl and wood that she ought to know all too well.

Not until it's too late. Not until it's gone quiet.

"Max?"

No answer. Acrid, gnawing dread takes hold of her.

"Max, dude, are you–"

Her room is empty.

The phone sits alone on the bed.

A chilled evening breeze worms its way through the half open window, rustling the scrap of paper on the floor beneath it. The notebook it originated from lays discarded at its side, along with an uncapped pen.

In a hasty, shaking facsimile of Max's handwriting: *I had to. Please stay out of trouble while I'm gone.*